

Applied Cognition Note 1: Attention Audit

Due: Tuesday, September 1 at 11:59 PM

Value: 15 points

Format: 500-700 word analysis

Purpose

Use selective-attention concepts to analyze how a real environment competes for limited attentional resources. The goal is to turn an everyday observation into a precise, evidence-based design recommendation.

Your task

- Choose one environment you can observe ethically for 20 minutes: a study space, transit stop, grocery aisle, or digital dashboard. Do not record names, faces, or private conversations.
- Create a time-stamped log of at least eight attention-relevant events, including one instance each of interruption, search, divided attention, and goal recovery.
- Classify each event using one course concept: attentional capture, bottleneck, top-down control, vigilance, or task switching.
- Explain which two features most interfere with the user's goal, then propose one feasible redesign and predict its benefit and tradeoff.

Required sources or materials

- Course Reader: 'Attention as Selection'
- Lecture notes on bottlenecks and attentional capture

Recommended workflow

- Select the setting and define the user's primary goal.
- Observe before interpreting.
- Draft the claim, then test it against at least one counterexample.

Submit

- One PDF containing the observation table and 500-700 word analysis.
- A final disclosure stating whether any AI or editing tool was used.

Important note

Observe behavior in public or your own workspace only. Do not photograph people or include identifying information.

Grading criteria

Criterion	Pts	Full-credit evidence
Accurate concept	4	Uses the assigned cognitive concept accurately and precisely.
Concrete evidence	4	Documents specific observations or examples rather than general impressions.
Analysis	5	Connects evidence to a defensible explanation and acknowledges a limitation.
Clarity and attribution	2	Meets length, organization, and citation expectations.

Submission standards

Upload a readable PDF unless the handout specifies another format. Include your name, course code, and assignment title. Cite borrowed ideas and retain the editable source file. The learning portal timestamp is the official submission time.